

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Mystery drama

DIRECTOR

Akira Kurosawa

WRITERS

Akira Kurosawa
(screenplay); Ryunosuke
Akutagawa (short stories)

STARS

Toshirô Mifune, Machiko
Kyô, Masayuki Mori,
Takashi Shimura

BEFORE

1943 Akira Kurosawa makes
his directorial debut with
Sanshiro Sugata, a historical
drama about the struggle
for supremacy between the
adherents of judo and jujitsu.

AFTER

1954 Kurosawa's *Seven
Samurai*, a 16th-century epic
in which a village enlists
seven warriors to protect
it from bandits, is widely
regarded as his masterpiece.

Akira Kurosawa's *Rashomon* is a thriller that revolves around two possible crimes that take place in a secluded glade: the rape of a woman (Machiko Kyô) and the violent death of the woman's samurai husband (Masayuki Mori). The truth, however, is hard to get at; it is tangled up in a knot of yarns spun by four eyewitnesses. Whom does the audience trust to tell them the truth? The alleged rape victim? The bandit accused of committing the offense? The ghost of the dead man? The woodcutter who found the body? Whose story is *the* story?

Beneath the gate

The opening shot of the movie is of the Rashomon city gate, a huge ruin in medieval Kyoto, seen from afar through a curtain of rain. Sheltering beneath the gate are a woodcutter (Takashi Shimura) and a priest (Minoru Chiaki), and they are soon joined by a commoner (Kichijirô Ueda). The newcomer strikes up a conversation, and

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Human beings are unable to be honest with themselves about themselves. They cannot talk about themselves without embellishing. This script portrays such human beings.

Akira Kurosawa

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is told about the crime and the subsequent arrest of the bandit Tajômaru (Toshirô Mifune).

As the woodcutter and the priest relate the tale, flashbacks show the bandit and the woman explaining what they saw at an inquest—or what they think they saw. Then a medium (Noriko

“Dead men tell no lies.”

The priest / *Rashomon***Akira Kurosawa** Director

Kurosawa was the first Japanese director to find popularity in the West. His movies *Rashomon*, *Seven Samurai*, and *Yojimbo* were remade as Westerns (*The Outrage* in 1964, *The Magnificent Seven* in 1960, and *A Fistful of Dollars* in 1964, respectively). Kurosawa ultimately found greater critical appreciation in Europe and the US than he did in his native country.

The son of an army officer, Kurosawa studied art before embarking on his career in

cinema, which saw him develop a sensibility that was partially Westernized. He experimented with courtroom drama, crime thriller, film noir, and medical melodrama. He continued making movies until his death in 1998.

Key movies

1950 *Rashomon*
1954 *Seven Samurai*
1961 *Yojimbo*
1985 *Ran*